Project Reflection: FreedomPath PH

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I keep asking myself the same question: am I saving or investing enough? Every calculator I've found online is built for someone with a 401k in the US, or it's a blog comparing bank rates with no connection to whether that rate actually gets you anywhere. Nobody puts the three pieces together: how much you need, where it should go, and whether you're actually closing the gap. That's what I wanted FreedomPath PH to be, small enough that I could actually finish it.

What it actually does

You fill out a short form: age, income, what you've already saved, your money goal, and a few questions about how you feel about risk. It gives you back a plan. How much to save every month. A rough estimate of your future SSS pension. And a recommended split between a regular savings account, Pag-IBIG MP2, and an investment fund matched to how much risk you're okay with.

The part I actually care about is that the AI isn't window dressing on top of a calculator. It reads your risk answers, figures out where you land, and writes the explanation and recommendation in plain language. That's real work. The one hard line I drew was the math itself: how much you need to save, your pension estimate, gets calculated the same way a regular calculator would, not guessed at by the AI. And it's only allowed to mention rates that come from a real, sourced list built into the project, not something it makes up on its own.

How much Claude helped

I've written a lot of specs and sat through a lot of build reviews as a PM, but I'd never actually built the thing myself before this. Claude was doing most of the actual building. I was steering: making the scope calls, deciding what mattered enough to keep. Where it helped the most was chasing down weird behavior. There was one bug where if you built a plan without an account and then tried to save it, you'd get sent to a sign-up page and lose everything you'd just typed in. Claude went in and clicked through the whole thing itself, signed out, rebuilt a plan, saved it, signed back in, checked what came back, until it was actually sure it worked instead of just assuming the fix looked right.

What was harder than expected

Staying small. Not the technical stuff. I'd already written down, before building anything, that trying to do too much was the biggest risk here, and I still caught myself wanting to add "just one more thing" more times than I'd like to admit. Sticking to the savings account, MP2, one investment option, and the pension estimate, and leaving everything else for later, was the right call. I had to keep reminding myself to stop there.

Biggest takeaway

The work before any building happened mattered just as much as the building itself. I already knew what to cut before I was even tempted to add it, because I'd done that thinking upfront instead of figuring out scope as I went.

And building in small steps, testing what it actually felt like to use after each change instead of waiting until the end, saved me more than once. That, paired with keeping this small instead of letting it balloon, is the difference between finishing something real and ending up with a half-built version of something much bigger.

What I'd add next

Two things I deliberately left out for now: PERA, another government retirement option, as a fourth thing people could put their money into, and a monthly email that nudges people to come back and update their numbers instead of just hoping they remember to. Both are logged as open items for a future version, not because they weren't worth doing, but because this first version needed to stay small enough to actually ship.